

Chevrolet volt

Unlike other hybrids, the actual propulsion of the Volt is accomplished by an electric motor

our products so that they do not pose any environmental risks at the end of their life".

Some facts and figures from Nokia's campaign: the company currently has around 5,000 recycle collection points worldwide (including 1,300 recycling bins in India) and works with 80 selected recycling plants throughout the world.

This campaign was run in four major metros, and in the first six weeks Nokia collected over 60,000 individual items, weighing just over three tons. These included around 10,000 mobile phones, 30,000 chargers and 12,000 batteries, together with other items such as headsets.

So, how does this all work in practice? We spoke to Pranshu Singhal, Nokia's Environmental Manager, based in Gurgaon. Surprisingly, he told us that Nokia does not release publicly the names of the recycling companies that it uses. However, he did give the name of the main one for India to us, and we will follow this up later and report on the company, and any others that are relevant. This company is not based in India yet, but in South-East Asia, and expects to open a plant in India in a couple of month's time. In the meantime, the e-waste is exported with the proper permits from both countries.

Nokia does its own auditing of plants such as this, and inspects them on average every six months to ensure proper practices are in place. The contracts with these companies are dependent on these inspections having positive results.

The number of materials that are recovered is large, but the main ones are plastics and metals. The plastics are converted into epoxy pellets for use in industrial processes. Most metals are recovered by electrolysis and are therefore recovered in a very pure state. They can then be reused either to make more mobile phones or any other products. Electrolysis might seem an energy-expensive process, but this actually saves energy when compared to mining and smelting.

At the other end of the whole process, Nokia told us of the substances that are being phased out of production processes for health and safety reasons. These include PVC, lead, mercury, cadmium, hexavalent chromium, polybrominated biphenyls (PBB), polybrominated diphenyl ethers (PBDE) and eight different phthalates. Nokia was not prepared to tell us how it was replacing these various substances.

For example phthalates are used to make plastics more flexible — less brittle and therefore less likely to break. If Nokia is no longer using these, then other substances are being

used instead. However, just which substances, is considered confidential, and we simply have to take Nokia's word for it that the replacements are safer or easier to recycle.

Clearly, this does not all come at no cost. The service is free to users, but obviously the cost is built into Nokia's accounting when it decides sale prices for its phones. It remains to be seen how long it can sustain the offer to recycle regardless of brand and if other mobile phone companies come round to offering a similar service.

Conclusions

Nokia is not the only company that has started either to introduce recycling schemes or to reduce the toxic materials used in its production processes. Among those relevant to our industry are Sony Ericsson, LG Electronics, Samsung, Sony, HP and Dell. No doubt there are others as well, and we do not imply any criticism by failing to be aware of their practices and reporting on them here. However, the situation in the IT industry is a very, very long way from where it should be, and the whole industry needs to be challenged to step up to this problem and confront it properly.

We have focused here on Nokia because of the very recent nature of its recycling campaign and because the company certainly seems to have a comprehensive approach to the problem of e-waste — the most comprehensive that we have come across. But in fairness, it is much easier for a mobile phone company to do this than a PC, or PC component vendor. The mobile phone is a single discrete unit, together with its battery and charger, purchased from one vendor and therefore returnable to one vendor.

But what of a graphics card or hard drive? The manufacturer of such a product has no control over the machine in which it is sold — it could go into a standard PC such as a Dell, a machine built locally by some dealer, or inserted by a PC owner who builds his own. Whose responsibility is it to see that the hard drive or graphics card properly gets recycled at the end of its days? Add printers, scanners and mice into the mix of a standard desktop setup, and you would probably be tempted just to throw it all in the local tip. But this is not the way!

It is up to us as users and consumers of these devices to pressure the industry. Once it becomes clear that we take the issues of e-waste and recycling seriously, then the industry will be bound to follow. If a hardware vendor is offering green-tech or supposedly environmentally friendly devices, then let's hear a properly constructed strategy for recycling and the avoidance of yet more e-waste piling up. ■

edward.henning@thinkdigit.com

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